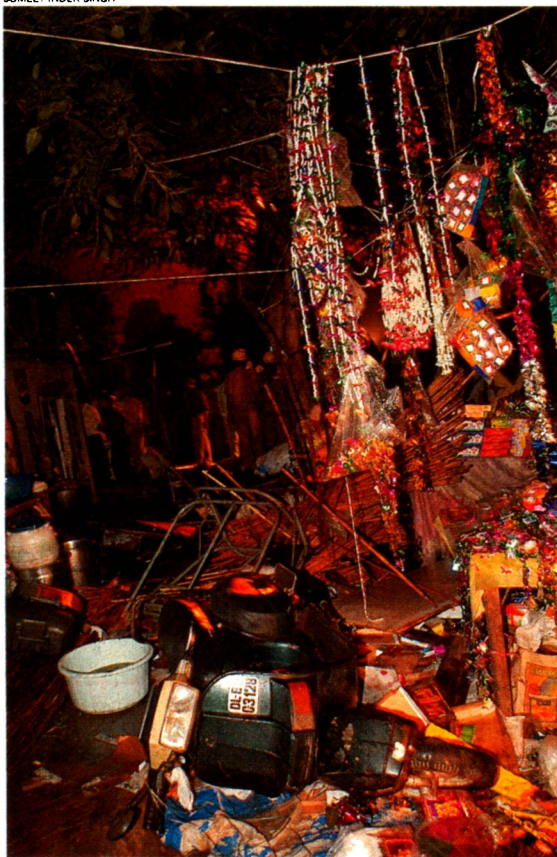


standards of human intelligence gathering have not kept pace with the new form of terror operations," says N.P.S Aulakh, DG, Punjab Police.

Despite tall claims, state police forces are invariably at sea where terrorist activities are concerned. They have no advance information and are no wiser after a tragedy. This is because states do not share information on investigations transparently. Every time a bomb rips through a city, the police not only do not reach the blast site quickly enough, but on reaching it, do little to make sure it is cordoned off to prevent tampering of evidence and to protect the public in case there are any improvised explosive devices yet to be detonated.

The real issue is the inadequate size of the police force as compared to the population. In the US and the UK, which have taken tough counter-terror measures, the ratio of police force to people is 1:300. In India the average is 1:728, with the gulf widening further in states like Bihar and Uttar Pradesh. Most police stations are short-staffed and ill-equipped to monitor their areas of operations.

SUMEETINDER SINGH



Gupta believes that the key to preventing such terror attacks is "improving information gathering and intelligence in what is known as last-mile connectivity at the ground level". He says the local police, right from the level of the beat constable, should be able to identify suspicious activity going on around them. The Centre has been asking the states to fill vacancies at the field level and to ensure that police stations are fully staffed and if need be, augmented.

GO HIGH ON TECH

Terrorists always remain a step ahead of the plethora of security and law enforcement agencies, whose turf wars ensure divided forces in the fight against terrorism. NTRO, created exclusively for collecting technical intelligence through satellites, computers, aircraft and radio intercepts, is yet to take off because other agencies refused to part with assets like monitoring facilities.

Nowhere is this rivalry more evident than on Shankaracharya Hill in Srinagar, where at least four intelligence agencies maintain separate monitoring facilities but do not consult one another. A proposal for creating a national database of intelligence that would allow all agencies to receive crucial real-time intelligence did not take off because the IB refused to share its intelligence. RAW's air wing, the Aviation Research Centre, scuttled an NTRO proposal to buy more aircraft, treating it as an encroachment on its traditional preserve of airborne intelligence. The IB reportedly stalled a proposal by BSF to acquire a satellite phone monitoring facility for similar reasons. Little wonder then that terrorists slip through these squabbles and wreak havoc.

"Combating terror has become a high technology game," says Gaurav Yadav, DIG, Punjab Police (Intelligence), who has been credited with busting several terror modules in the state. "Most of the state intelligence wings lack sophisticated equipment to monitor terrorists' communication networks," he adds. State intelligence units are usually hamstrung by a lack of resources to buy the latest gadgetry off-the-shelves. Apart from a superb communications monitoring network, there is a need for an integrated automated fingerprint identification system that offers electronic search and storage capabilities.

DELHI BLASTS, OCTOBER 29, 2005

The Union Home Ministry is pushing for security benchmarks for malls that include mandatory CCTV and access control systems